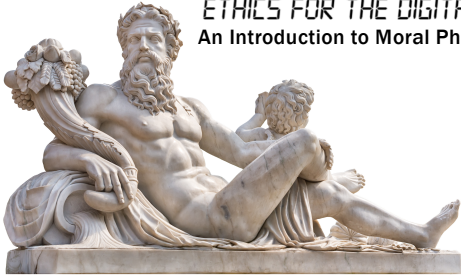


PHIL 1001
ETHICS FOR THE DIGITAL AGE
An Introduction to Moral Philosophy



Week 02, Lect. A
The Divine Command Theory 

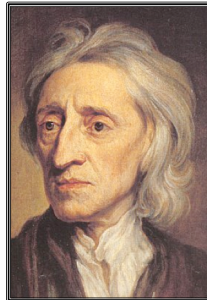
Agenda

- I. What is The Divine Command Theory?
- II. Clarificatory Questions
- III. Theoretical Considerations
Favouring DCT.
- VI. An Argument in Favour of DCT. 



Part I:
What is the
Divine Command
Theory?

John Locke (1632-1704)
Essay Concerning Human Understanding (1689)



John Locke (1632-1704)
Essay Concerning Human Understanding (1689)

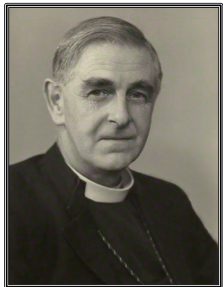
“First, **the Divine Law**, whereby I mean that Law which God has set to the actions of Men...

This is the only true touchstone of moral Rectitude;

and by comparing them [i.e., human actions] to this Law, it is, that Men judge of most considerable Moral Good or Evil of their Actions...”

p. 352

Robert C. Mortimer
(1952)



Robert C. Mortimer, Bishop of Exeter (1902-1976)

Robert C. Mortimer
(1952)

“From the doctrine of God as the Creator and source of all that is, it follows that a thing is not right simply because we think it is, still less because it seems to be expedient.

It is right because God commands it.

This means that there is a real distinction between right and wrong which is independent of what we happen to think. It is rooted in the nature and will of God.”

A First Attempt to Formulate The Divine Command Theory

DCT*: An act, x, is morally right if and only if x is commanded by God.

A Problem for DCT*?

Did God command Sgt. Smith to eat his donut this morning?

If not, then DCT* implies that Smith's act of eating the donut was morally wrong!



A Better Formulation of The Divine Command Theory

DCT: An act, x, is morally right if and only if x does not violate any of God's commands.

DCT embodies two claims:

- (1) Any act that **does not** violate God's commands is **morally right** —i.e. **permissible; okay to do**
- (2) Any act that **does** violate God's commands is **NOT morally right** —i.e. **wrong; not okay**.

Understanding DCT: DCT Applied

The act token? → Uncle Midnight's stealing a car on April 12, 1986

Has God issued a command that this act-token violates? → ?



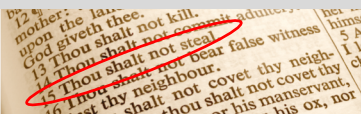
A Few (Very Serious) Questions.

Q1: Does God exist?

Q2: Has God actually commanded anything of humans?

Q3: Assuming the answer to Q1 and Q2 is "yes":
How do we learn about what God has commanded?

<< For the sake of illustrating how DCT works, suppose that the 10 commandments of The Hebrew Bible accurately represent some of God's commands.>

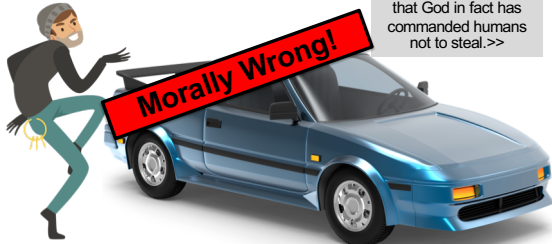


<<(If you are reading these slides without listening to the lecture, rest assured that I DID NOT announce to the class that I think I know what the one true religion is, or which religious text is true. In fact, the point I was making on this slide was quite the opposite: I'm sure I don't know which religion(s), if any, is true.)>>

The act token? → Uncle Midnight's stealing a car on April 12, 1986

Has God issued a command that this act-token violates? → **Yes.**

<< Assuming, again, that God in fact has commanded humans not to steal.>>



Part II: Clarificatory Questions

DCT: An act, x, is morally right if and only if
x does not violate any of God's commands.

What do you mean by 'God'?



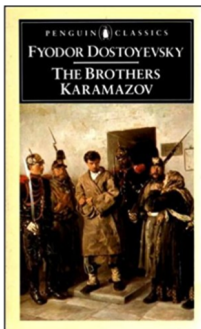
DCT: An act, x, is morally right if and only if
x does not violate any of God's commands.

Do you have to be
Christian in order
to accept DCT?



DCT: An act, x, is morally right if and only if
x does not violate any of God's commands.

Do you have to be a
theist to accept DCT?



"If God does not exist,
then everything is permitted."^{*}

^{*} Not a real quote from the book, evidently.

DCT: An act, x, is morally right if and only if
x does not violate any of God's commands.

What if God exists
but did not command
anything?



Part III: Theoretical Considerations in Favour of DCT

Some theoretically appealing features of DCT:

- (a) Makes sense of the common thought that morality is closely **tied to religion** and/or God.
- (b) Makes it possible to understand morality as **a kind of law**.
- (c) Supports the **objectivity & universality** of morality.



The Argument from Reasons for Acting

Two attractive theses about morality and reasons:

Moral Rationalism

MR: if a person has a **moral obligation** to x, then that person has a **reason** to x.

Desire-Based Theory of Reasons

(DBR) A person has a **reason** to do x only if doing x would satisfy some **desire** of hers.

A person has a reason **to refrain** from x only if x would frustrate some desire of hers.

A potential problem case?

The psychopathic emperor ...e.g., "Caligula"



- enjoys torturing commoners for amusement.
- feels no empathy, no guilt, & no shame.
- No human beings who disapprove are powerful enough to punish him.

Three Tasks for us:

Step 1: **STATE** the argument.

Step 2: **EXPLAIN** the argument.

Step 3: **EVALUATE** the argument.

1. Statement of the Argument

Statement of the Argument from Reasons for Acting

P1. Caligula has a moral obligation not to torture.

P2. Caligula has a moral obligation not to torture
only if DCT is true.

C. DCT is true.

2. Explanation of the Argument

< Rationale for premise 2 – in outline >

P2. Caligula has a moral obligation not to torture
only if DCT is true.

Suppose that Caligula really does have an **obligation** not to torture.

- (a) Because of MR: he has **a reason** not to torture.
- (b) Because of DBR: he has **a desire** that would be frustrated if he tortures people.
- (c) Because of Caligula's political power & lack of empathy,
only God can frustrate his desires.
- (d) So, Caligula will have an obligation not to torture
only if **God is the author** and **enforcer** of moral rules.

3. Evaluation of the Argument

Three potential responses to P2 of the argument from practical reasons:

- (R1) reject moral rationalism (MR).
- (R2) reject the Desire-Based Theory of Reasons (DBR).
- (R3) Argue that God can and might enforce the moral law even if He is not its creator or author.

